

THE PENINSULAR PLATEAU

Central Highlands • Deccan Plateau • Ghats • Eastern Extension

Physiographic Divisions of India — Landform Notes for SSC / UPSSSC / UPPSC / Railways

- Headings & Definitions ● Explanations ● Highlighter = Key Facts 🎯 Exam Tip ✗ Common Mistake
🧠 Memory Trick

StudyPlanner



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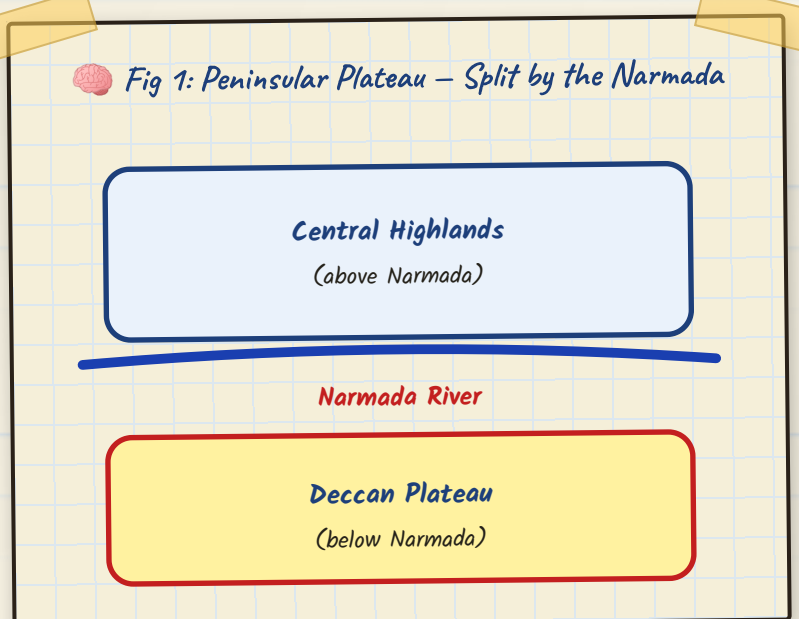
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THE PENINSULAR PLATEAU — OVERVIEW

The Peninsular Plateau is the largest landform of India. We divide it into two parts using the Narmada River as the dividing line:

- The part above the Narmada Valley → the Central Highlands
- The part below the Narmada Valley → the Deccan Plateau

🧠 Fig 1: Peninsular Plateau — Split by the Narmada



Central Highlands — Smaller Plateaus (in order)

1. Mewar (also called Marwar) Plateau

2. Malwa Plateau
3. Bundelkhand
4. Baghelkhand
5. Chota Nagpur Plateau

Memory Trick

Just memorise the order: **Mewar** → **Malwa** → **Bundelkhand** → **Baghelkhand** → **Chota Nagpur**. No need to go deeper into Bundelkhand or Baghelkhand for exams.

Aravalli Range – Northwest Extension

- The Aravalli is a **fold mountain** — specifically an **old fold mountain** (fold mountains are of two types: young fold mountains and old fold mountains)
- Also known as **residual mountains**
- Extends across: **Gujarat** → **Rajasthan** → **Haryana** → **Delhi**
- Highest peak: **Guru Shikhar**, height **1722 metres**, located on **Mount Abu Hills**



The **Chota Nagpur Plateau** is known as the "**Ruhr of India**" because it's an extremely mineral-rich region.



Quick Recap

Old fold + residual = Aravalli. Highest point = Guru Shikhar (1722 m) on Mount Abu.
Mineral-rich = Chota Nagpur = "Ruhr of India"!

Exam Tip

A frequently asked question: which states does the Aravalli Range extend across?
Remember the full chain — **Gujarat, Rajasthan, Haryana, and Delhi**.

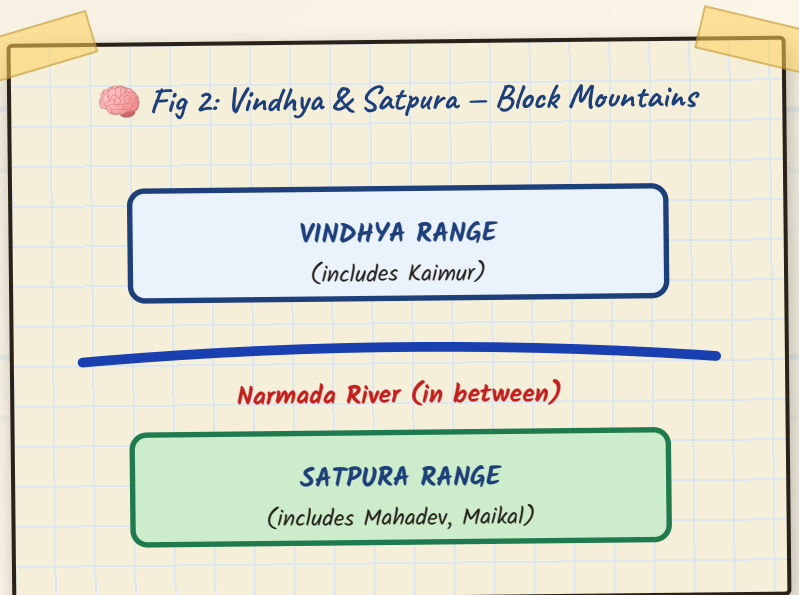
VINDHYA, SATPURA + THE DECCAN PLATEAU

Vindhya & Satpura Ranges

Within the Central Highlands, we also see the Vindhya Range (lying above/north) and the Satpura Range (lying below/south). Both are types of Block Mountains.

- Satpura range includes the Mahadev and Maikal hills
- Vindhya range includes the Kaimur hills
- In Maharashtra, we also find the Satmala Hills, Harishchandra Range, and Balaghat Range
- The Narmada River flows in the valley between the Vindhya and Satpura ranges

Fig 2: Vindhya & Satpura – Block Mountains



Memory Trick

Vindhya = North (above); Satpura = South (below) — and the Narmada flows right through the valley between the two Block Mountain ranges.

The Deccan Plateau

The part of the Peninsular Plateau below the Narmada is the Deccan Plateau.

- Western boundary: the Western Ghats
- Eastern boundary: the Eastern Ghats
- Overall tilt: from west to east

- Height increases from north to south

✗ Common Mistake

Don't mix up the tilt direction with the height trend — the Deccan Plateau **tilts west→east**, but its **height rises north→south**. These are two separate facts!



Understand it like this...

Picture the Deccan Plateau as a tilted tabletop: one edge (west) is propped up higher than the other (east) — that's the tilt. Separately, walking from the top (north) to the bottom (south) of that tabletop, the ground itself gets higher.

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WESTERN GHATS VS EASTERN GHATS Hills of the Eastern Ghats

Nallamala Hills, Venukonda Hills (Andhra Pradesh), Palakonda, Nagari, Javadi, Shevaroy, Panchamalai, Shirumalai, Palani, and Vaishnava Hills.

Hills of the Western Ghats

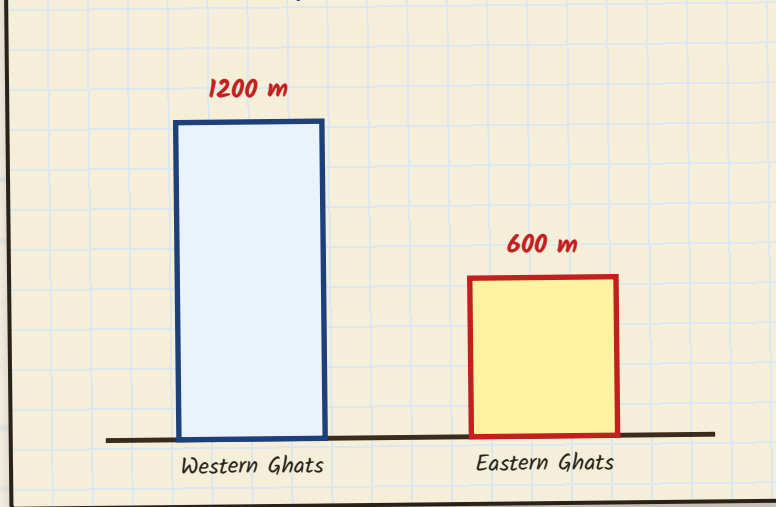
Nilgiri Hills, Anamalai Hills, and Cardamom Hills.

Western Ghats vs Eastern Ghats — Comparison

Feature	Western Ghats	Eastern Ghats
Average height	1,200 m (higher)	600 m (lower)
Continuity	Continuous	Discontinuous
Highest peak	Anaimudi — 2695 m	Mahendragiri — 1501 m

The Eastern Ghats are **discontinuous** because most rivers flow **towards the east** (following the west-to-east tilt of the Deccan Plateau) and cut through them as they go.

Fig 3: Height Comparison



Because the Western Ghats are higher, they also hold the **highest peak in all of South India**: **Anaimudi**, height **2695 metres**, part of the **Anamalai Hills** (in Kerala).

✦ For the Eastern Ghats, the highest peak as given in **NCERT** is **Mahendragiri** (1501 m) — even though peaks like Jindagada or Arma Konda are sometimes mentioned elsewhere, **NCERT's answer is Mahendragiri**, so memorise that for exams.

The **second-highest peak** overall (after Anaimudi) is **Dodabetta**, located in the **Nilgiri Hills**, in **Tamil Nadu**.

✖ **Common Mistake**

Anaimudi is in **Kerala**; Dodabetta is in **Tamil Nadu** — don't swap the states for these two peaks.

🎯 **Exam Tip**

For Eastern Ghats' highest peak, always go with the **NCERT** answer — **Mahendragiri (1501 m)** — even if other sources mention different peaks.

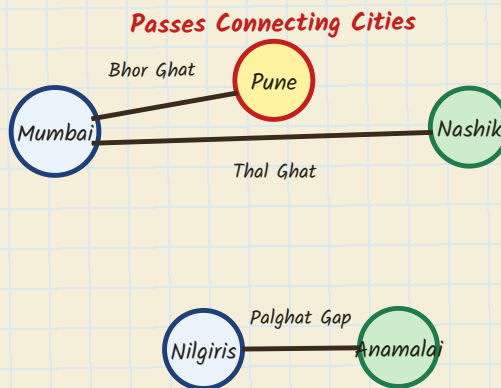
PASSES + GAPS CONNECTING THE GHATS

The Anamalai Hills connect to the Nilgiri Hills through a pass called

Palghat (Palakkad) Gap.

There are two more important passes, similar to Palghat but found further north (both connecting Mumbai to other cities):

Fig 4: Ghats & Passes of Peninsular India



Pass	Connects
Palghat (Palakkad) Gap	Nilgiri Hills ↔ Anamalai Hills
Thal Ghat	Mumbai ↔ Nashik
Bhor Ghat	Mumbai ↔ Pune

Memory Trick

"Bhor" means dawn/morning in Hindi — you head out early in the morning for work, to **Pune** → **Bhor Ghat** = **Mumbai-Pune**. By evening you might be enjoying Nashik's wines → **Thal Ghat** = **Mumbai-Nashik**.

Fun fact

Nashik is often called India's "wine capital" — that's the link this mnemonic uses to remember the Thal Ghat connection!

Exam Tip

All three passes are important connectors within the Peninsular Plateau's Ghats — remember them as a set: **Palghat, Thal Ghat, Bhor Ghat**.

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EASTERN EXTENSION — RAJMAHAL HILLS + KARBI ANGLONG

At the easternmost edge of the entire Peninsular Plateau, we find the **Rajmahal Hills** (in Jharkhand) and the **Garhjat Hills** (in Odisha).

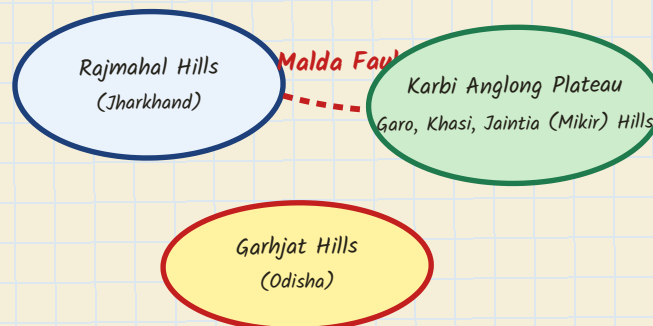
The extension of the Rajmahal Hills continues further as the **Garo, Khasi, and Jaintia Hills** (also called the **Mikir Hills**) — these are collectively known as the **Karbi Anglong Plateau**.

✗ Common Mistake

The Garo-Khasi-Jaintia (Karbi Anglong) hills are part of the **Peninsular Plateau** — NOT part of the Himalayas, even though they lie in the northeast!

The gap between the Rajmahal Hills and the Karbi Anglong Plateau is known as the **Malda Fault** (or Malda Gap).

Fig 5: Eastern Extension of the Peninsular Plateau



Exam Tip

Remember the eastern chain: **Rajmahal Hills** → **Malda Fault/Gap** → **Karbi Anglong Plateau (Garo-Khasi-Jaintia/Mikir Hills)** — all part of the Peninsular Plateau, not the Himalayas.

★ Exam-Ready Summary

- **Largest landform of India:** Peninsular Plateau — split by the Narmada into Central Highlands (above) and Deccan Plateau (below)
- **Aravalli:** old fold/residual mountain; Gujarat → Rajasthan → Haryana → Delhi; highest peak Guru Shikhar (1722 m, Mount Abu)
- **Chota Nagpur Plateau:** "Ruhr of India" — mineral rich
- **Vindhya (north) & Satpura (south):** Block Mountains, with the Narmada flowing between them
- **Deccan Plateau:** tilts west → east; height rises north → south; bounded by Western & Eastern Ghats
- **Western Ghats:** higher (1200 m avg), continuous; highest peak Anaimudi (2695 m, Kerala)
- **Eastern Ghats:** lower (600 m avg), discontinuous; highest peak Mahendragiri (1501 m, per NCERT)
- **2nd highest peak overall:** Dodabetta (Nilgiri Hills, Tamil Nadu)
- **Passes:** Palghat Gap (Nilgiri ↔ Anamalai), Thal Ghat (Mumbai ↔ Nashik), Bhor Ghat (Mumbai ↔ Pune)
- **Eastern extension:** Rajmahal Hills → Malda Fault/Gap → Karbi Anglong Plateau (Garo-Khasi-Jaintia/Mikir Hills)

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